ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Hostel and Off-Campus Living: Rent, Roommates and Realistic Costs

Choose accommodation with your eyes open and live with fewer conflicts

CAMPUS LIFE

Campus Life

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Accommodation decisions affect cost, safety, study time and stress. This pack covers comparing hostel and off-campus options, inspecting a lodge before paying, understanding rent and agency fees, and managing shared living without daily conflict.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Compare hostel and off-campus options on cost, safety and study conditions.
- Inspect accommodation and verify ownership before paying.
- Budget for hidden accommodation costs.
- Set shared-living rules that prevent common conflicts.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Choose on criteria, not pressure

Accommodation is a package: rent, transport, utilities, security and study environment.

- Hostel advantages: proximity, campus security, less commuting. Disadvantages: crowding, rules and limited privacy.
- Off-campus advantages: space and flexibility. Disadvantages: transport cost, landlord risk and security variability.
- Calculate total monthly cost, not just rent.
- Consider distance to your faculty, not just to the main gate.
- Check water, power and network coverage at different times of day.

- Decide before the last week of vacation; panic raises both price and risk.

Inspect and verify

Never pay for a room you have not entered, and never pay without documentation.

1. Visit in person and inspect the room, toilet, water source and wiring.
2. Speak to current tenants about the landlord, security and interruptions.
3. Confirm ownership or the agent's authority to collect rent.
4. Read the tenancy agreement, including duration, notice and refund terms.
5. Pay through a traceable method and collect a signed receipt.
6. Photograph the room's condition at handover.

> **The too-cheap warning**
> A rent far below the area average is either misrepresented or unsafe. Inspect with a friend and never be rushed by 'another person is paying today'.

Living with others

Most roommate conflict is unspoken expectation, not malice.

- Agree on cleaning rotas, cooking, noise hours and guest rules in the first week.
- Agree on how shared bills are collected and recorded.
- Respect boundaries around food, clothes and personal items.
- Raise a problem early and privately rather than accumulating resentment.
- Secure your valuables; familiarity does not remove risk.
- Keep an emergency contact and know the nearest health facility.

Choosing where to live

Hostel allocation is cheap and inconvenient; off-campus is expensive and freer. The real decision variables are cost, distance, security, water, power, noise and the reliability of the landlord. Rank them before you view anything, because in the viewing you will be persuaded by the thing you ranked last.

Distance is measured in minutes and money, not kilometres. A room thirty minutes' walk away costs you five hours a week and a great deal of energy; a room near a transport route may be better than one that is technically closer. Visit at the time of day you will actually travel.

Never pay for a room you have not seen, and never pay without a receipt and a written agreement. The commonest student housing loss is a deposit paid to someone who did not own the property.

The practicalities nobody explains

Water and power determine daily quality of life more than room size. Ask current tenants, not the landlord, when water runs and how often power comes. Check the condition of the roof, the windows, the toilet and the wiring, and photograph everything before you move in.

Cooking, laundry and study space are the three functions that decide whether a room works. A room with no ventilation cannot be studied in during the hot season. A shared kitchen with no storage produces conflict. Plan these before signing.

House rules prevent most disputes: who cleans what, how bills are split, quiet hours, guests, and what happens when someone leaves. Write them down, even in a hostel. An unwritten rule is a rule someone will claim never existed.

> **Photograph before you move in**
> Dated photographs of the room's condition are the difference between getting your deposit back and losing it.

Living with others

Conflict in shared accommodation is usually about unspoken expectations rather than malice. Raise an issue early and specifically: "the dishes are being left for two days and it is attracting insects" is actionable; "you people are inconsiderate" is not.

Keep money arrangements separate from friendship. Shared bills should have a named collector, a written record and a fixed date. Lending to a housemate is a decision to risk the friendship and the money.

Safety is collective: a shared lock, agreed visitor rules, and knowing who has a key. A room that is safe when you are there alone may be unsafe when five people are coming and going.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Comparing two rooms

Room A is cheaper but 45 minutes away with unreliable water. Room B is 25 per cent more expensive, 10 minutes away, with a borehole.

1. Calculate the transport cost of Room A over a semester.
2. Value the time: 90 minutes a day, five days a week.
3. Add the cost of buying water for Room A.
4. Compare total cost, not rent.
5. Weigh the academic cost of fatigue and missed evening study.
6. Choose and state the assumption that could change the decision.

> **What to carry forward**
> Compare total cost and total time. Rent is the smallest part of housing cost.

2. Setting up a written house agreement

Four students share a flat.

1. List shared costs and how each is split.
2. Name who collects and who holds the record.
3. Agree cleaning responsibilities by area and day.
4. Agree quiet hours and guest rules.
5. Agree notice period and procedure for a replacement tenant.
6. All four sign and keep a copy.

> **What to carry forward**
> Write it while everyone is friendly. That is when it is still possible.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. What should a student check before paying for accommodation?

10 marks

1. Ownership and authority to let.
2. Condition of water, power, roof, toilet and wiring.
3. Distance and transport at the relevant times.
4. Written agreement and receipt.
5. Photographic record of condition.

Q2. Explain why shared accommodation disputes are usually about expectations.

10 marks

1. Unspoken rules differ between households.
2. Conflict arises from unmet assumptions rather than intent.
3. Written house rules and early specific communication prevent escalation.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Tenancy agreement. A written contract setting out the terms of renting.

Deposit. Money held against damage or unpaid rent, refundable on conditions.

Borehole. A drilled water source, often shared by a compound.

House rules. Agreed expectations about cleaning, noise, guests and bills.

Shared cost. A bill divided among occupants, requiring a record.

Ventilation. The movement of air through a space, essential for comfort and study.

Agent. An intermediary who arranges lettings for an owner.

Notice period. The agreed time before leaving a tenancy.

Subletting. Renting out a space one already rents, often requiring permission.

Commuting cost. The money and time spent travelling to campus.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Criteria

Decide what matters.

- Rank cost, distance, security, water, power, noise.
- Set a maximum total monthly cost.
- List questions for current tenants.

Week 2 - Inspect

Evidence.

- Visit three options at realistic times.
- Photograph conditions.
- Verify ownership and get a receipt.

Week 3 - Agree

Paperwork.

- Write the tenancy or house agreement.
- Agree bill splitting and records.
- Set quiet hours and guest rules.

Week 4 - Settle

Routine.

- Establish cleaning rota.
- Locate water, power and security contacts.
- Review the first month's actual costs.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your university's accommodation policy.
- A tenant rights summary for your state.
- A personal finance guide section on shared living costs.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name three costs beyond rent.

Answer: Transport, electricity or fuel, water, security levies, and replacement of shared items.

2. Why inspect accommodation in person?

Answer: Listings and photographs can misrepresent space, water, security and condition, and payment without inspection is irrecoverable.

3. What should a tenancy agreement cover?

Answer: Duration, rent and payment schedule, obligations for repairs, notice period, refund terms and conditions for termination.

4. What is the best way to raise a roommate problem?

Answer: Early, privately and specifically, proposing a rule or solution rather than making it personal.

5. How can you reduce risk when paying rent?

Answer: Verify ownership, use a traceable payment method, obtain a signed receipt and keep a copy of the agreement.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Compare two accommodation options on total cost.
- [ ] Visit and inspect before any payment.
- [ ] Speak to at least two current tenants.
- [ ] Read the agreement and photograph it.
- [ ] Photograph the room at handover.
- [ ] Agree shared rules and a cleaning rota in week one.
- [ ] Save emergency and campus security contacts.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Campus Life | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

Hostel and Off-Campus Living: Rent, Roommates and Realistic Costs